

Direct democracy

Right now, big decisions are often made without fully hearing from the public—or only from the loudest or most powerful voices. Polarisation, fueled by politicians from both sides, makes it ever harder to find common ground. Many New Zealanders feel alienated or demoralised by politics; political participation is in long-term decline.

Our political system is also not well equipped to address long-term issues. Politicians are naturally focused on the three-year electoral cycle. But the most important issues for New Zealand are often longer term, like climate change, the impacts of an ageing population or our constitutional future.

What if there were a way to ensure that New Zealanders had a direct voice in the big, long-term decisions that will affect their lives most?

Opportunity will:

- **Convene citizens assemblies to consider and advise on major issues**
The citizens assembly will provide deep consideration of issues that are difficult to navigate and impact New Zealand's long-term future. The assembly will consist of a broadly representative group recruited at random from across the country. It will consider evidence from experts, interest groups and other citizens and make recommendations that the Government must respond to.
- **Appoint a Parliamentary Commissioner for Citizens' Voice**
This independent role will be responsible for enabling citizen participation in solving the most important long-term issues for society. Like the Ombudsman, the Commissioner will be appointed by Parliament, and will work independently from both the government and Parliament. They will focus on what's best for New Zealand in the long term—not just what's popular today.
- **Use other tools for broad-based citizen participation**
The Parliamentary Commissioner will also provide online and offline ways to enable citizen participation tailored to the issue being considered. These could include online surveys and digital deliberation tools as well as in-person public forums and hui.

What it means for you

- **Better decisions:** With broad input, policies are more likely to work and to gain public support.
- **A stronger democracy:** This process ensures decisions are informed by the people who live with their consequences.
- **A way through intractable issues:** Citizens assemblies can consider issues that politicians are too scared to touch, or that have become too politicised for reasonable debate, finding a way through the mire.
- **A real voice:** Whether through a survey, a workshop, or a forum, there will be more ways to share your views on the issues that matter most.

This isn't about replacing elections or Parliament. It's about improving how decisions are made, especially on big challenges that require long-term thinking and public buy-in.

Our representative democracy can struggle to address long-term issues

Big decisions are typically made by politicians with advice from experts, pressure from lobbyists and donors, or consultation that only reaches a limited audience. This can lead to outcomes that prioritise immediate electoral prospects over the long-term. Governments from both sides “kick the can down the road” on issues that will have a massive impact on New Zealand but are too slow-moving to result in an immediate crisis, or require solutions that cannot be implemented within one Parliamentary term. Current examples include the housing crisis, climate change and the impacts of our ageing population.





Photo: Climate Assembly UK

Citizens assemblies can make better and more democratic decisions

An assembly will have the same number of citizens as MPs in the current Parliament. They will be randomly selected to be representative of New Zealand's population. The assembly will be guided by a suitably qualified facilitator and supported by politically neutral, professional staff. Assembly meetings will take place using a mixture of in-person and online formats. Given the complexity of the issues at stake, and the need to build consensus, each assembly may last for up to a year.

The critical difference here is that recommendations will come directly from the people involved in these processes, not from politicians, officials or experts, or groups with vested interests. But the assembly won't simply consider the issue based on members' knowledge. It will hear evidence from experts, interest groups and the wider public, and can commission research.

Participatory decision-making will build consensus and public support. The process of making a decision can be as important as the decision itself. Citizens coming together to debate and find solutions to big issues can help to build consensus and deep support for agreed outcomes. It can also build a broader sense of "buy-in" to democratic processes.

All documents the Citizens Assembly considers will be made public (with limited exceptions to preserve the likes of privacy or commercial sensitivity) and, to the greatest extent possible, proceedings will be open to the public and allow opportunities for input in a variety of ways.

By contrast, current politics is leaving an increasing number of New Zealanders feeling alienated and demoralised. Voter turnout at local and national elections continues to slide and our political discourse – often online – is becoming ever more polarised. Politicians from both sides take advantage of and fuel this polarisation.

The Treaty Principles Bill has highlighted this issue. The Bill itself is short-sighted and deeply divisive. But there is a real need to have a national conversation about our Constitutional arrangements, including the role of Te Tiriti. That conversation needs to involve all New Zealanders – and most especially the two parties to the Treaty. It has the potential to shape how we define ourselves as a nation for generations to come – far too important an issue to leave to the politicians.

A Parliamentary Commissioner will facilitate a wide range of direct democratic participation

The Commissioner will oversee a range of public engagement processes, tailored to the issue at hand. The Commissioner's role is to ensure the process is fair, inclusive, and well-informed – but the ideas and solutions are generated by the participants themselves. The most important of these will be the citizens assemblies, but these will be supported by a range of innovative tools to enable participation by a broad range of citizens, facilitated by the Parliamentary Commissioner. These will include public forums and hui as well as digital tools such as surveys and online deliberative platforms.

For example, if Parliament wanted advice on how to provide affordable, accessible healthcare, the Commissioner might gather public input through digital platforms, community forums, and citizen panels to develop thoughtful, inclusive recommendations.

Topic selection will promote democratic participation

Topics could be identified in several ways:

- **Parliamentary Requests:** Parliament could ask the Commissioner to focus on specific challenges.
- **Public Petitions:** If enough people (for example 150,000 signatories) call for a topic to be explored, it could trigger action.
- **Independent Initiative:** The Commissioner might identify critical issues based on research or public discourse.
- **Community Feedback:** Input from iwi, community groups, or experts could highlight pressing concerns.

The decision process will be transparent, with clear criteria focused on importance, complexity, and public relevance.

Parliament will have to respond to citizens' recommendations

Once a process is completed, recommendations will be submitted to Parliament, which will be required to debate them and provide a formal response.

The Commissioner will monitor Parliament's responses to recommendations, tracking actions taken, and producing annual reports on the outcomes. These reports will be made public to ensure transparency and accountability.